



Tabakovic tapped in from close range to send the game into extra time and eventually penalties.

Things only got worse from there for Italy as substitutes Pio Esposito and Bryan Cristante failed to hit the target, while Bosnia was spotless from the spot to win 4-1 and secure an epic qualification.

For Italy, the wait to feature in 'the greatest show on Earth' will extend to at least 16 years now, with its last World Cup knockout match coming when it won the title in 2006.

Meanwhile, a shootout was required for Czech Republic to edge Denmark and book its place in the tournament. Czech midfielder Pavel Sulc's thunderous third-minute volley set the ball rolling, and Joachim Andersen took the game to extra time, where Ladislav Krejci and Kasper Høgh found the back of the net for Czechia and Denmark, respectively. In the shootout, Christian Eriksen was the only Dane to score, while Tomas Chory, Thomas Soucek and Michal Sadilek converted

for Czechia to send it to its first World Cup since 2006.

While Italy was the talk of the qualifying playoff tournament, Sweden also captured headlines after edging Poland 3-2 in their decider, thanks to an 88th-minute winner from star striker Viktor Gyokeres (left, centre). While the Swedes were deserved winners on the night, their participation in the playoffs in the first place has been a hot topic.

Sweden had a disastrous European Qualifiers campaign, where it failed to win any of its six matches, finishing behind Slovenia, Kosovo and Switzerland.

However, Sweden was handed a fresh roll of the dice because it won its UEFA Nations League group — and mind you, it was the third tier of the competition. The backdoor entry raised questions regarding UEFA ranking systems after teams like Italy and Kosovo, which ended qualifying with more wins, had to play in the same playoff tournament as Sweden.

But these noises will not bother the men in yellow, who will be making their first World Cup appearance since 2018, with Graham Potter summing the saga up with the words, "We weren't perfect, but who cares? We're going to the World Cup, baby. Wow."

Joining them in the summer will be Türkiye, which ended a 24-year World Cup drought after edging past Kosovo (below) thanks to a second-half strike from Kerem Aktürkoglu.

Aside from the European matches, two spots were up for grabs from the intercontinental playoffs. DR Congo, which slayed African giants Nigeria and Cameroon, clinched the first berth after defeating Jamaica in extra time. Axel Tuanzebe finished from close range with 10 minutes to go, sending the central African nation to its first World Cup since the 1974 edition in West Germany, where it competed as Zaire.

Iraq became the final team out of 48 to qualify by beating Bolivia 2-1 and will travel to North America for only its second appearance in the competition.

*(All results updated as of April 5)*

